

ADCLOD Podcast Series with Social Impact Founders

Episode 16: Minar Pimple, YUVA and MP Consulting

Neharika Vohra: Welcome to the ADCLOD podcast series with social impact founders, an initiative by the Ashank Desai Centre for Leadership and Organisational Development at IIM Ahmedabad, where we document and celebrate the leadership journeys of India's social entrepreneurs and practitioners. Today's session focuses on the development of social impact leaders and their organisations.

Neharika Vohra: Today's guest has spent four decades at the intersection of civil society, institutional leadership and global development, and is now channelling that experience into building capacity across India's social sector through his consulting practice. Minar Pimple co-founded YUVA — Youth for Unity and Voluntary Action — in 1984 at the age of 23, together with peers from the Nirmala Niketan College of Social Work, and led it for 20 years. Under his leadership, YUVA became one of India's most recognised civil society organisations, working with marginalised urban and rural communities on housing rights, labour, environment and participatory governance. He handed over to a new CEO in 2004, in a planned transition that itself became a model for institutional continuity in the sector. He subsequently served as founder chair of Oxfam India and regional director of the UN Millennium Campaign for Asia-Pacific, bringing a rare combination of grassroots, national and global experience to each role. Drawing on this breadth of experience, Minar now leads MP Consulting, where he works with social sector organisations on strategy, leadership development and organisational effectiveness. In today's conversation, we explore what that work involves, what the sector most needs, and what it takes to build lasting institutional capacity in India. We are delighted to welcome you to this podcast, Minar. It is an honour and a pleasure to speak with you.

Minar Pimple: Thank you very much for that very generous introduction, and thank you to the Ashank Desai Centre at IIM Ahmedabad for inviting me as a guest on this podcast. I really look forward to this conversation, which I hope will reach widely, and from which many different people will learn a great deal.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you so much. Minar, in almost all our other episodes, we have focused on the work done by the leader and the organisation they have built. With you, we are consciously choosing to speak about MP Consulting — a relatively new organisation you have set up — because you are very well known in the social sector for the capacity development work you are doing. So let me ask you the first question: what is the nature of MP Consulting's work? What kinds of organisations are you serving, and what kinds of assignments does it typically take on?

Minar Pimple: Let me give you a little history. MP Consulting also stands for "Motivation for Performance" — MP are my initials, but motivation for performance is the tagline I work with. I actually established MP Consulting in 2019. I had finished my assignment as senior director of global operations with Amnesty International in September that year, and I came back to India and set this up, because I had already decided I no longer wanted to lead organisations — leadership roles, front-facing roles. I wanted to be supporting leaders and organisations instead. That was the belief I had in 2019. So I registered the firm in India, and almost simultaneously I registered a global consulting firm in London.

Very interestingly, in December 2019, the Asia director of one of the large philanthropies in the world called me. She knew me from earlier, and she said, you can't retire so early — please come and work with me. Help me with our country offices and our regional office, and with how we can be more effective as a global institution working in the Asia region. That is how I got my first international consulting assignment, working with that philanthropy's different country offices in the Asia-Pacific region. I took that consultancy on through the London firm, and I had a colleague based in London who specialised in human resources, because this assignment was about the organisation and its effectiveness — looking at the pain points they were facing and how to overcome them. That is how my consulting journey began.

During COVID, of course, all the country visits stopped, but I still did a lot of remote work with that philanthropy's country offices. As things opened up, this person moved into a more senior position and said, with your experience of working with the United Nations, with Amnesty International, and of managing the Oxfam merger, I want you to come and work with me as director of the transformation team. So from 2021 to 2024, I became a full-time employee of a large philanthropy with offices in London, Singapore and other parts of the world — again, global work. Once the first phase of the transformation was complete, my role was complete. In September 2024 I came back, because my parents' physical health was getting worse and I needed to be permanently in India, accessible and available. From then on, I started doing more India-focused work, because I didn't want to be out of the country if an emergency happened — the time lag becomes considerable.

So from September 2024, I relaunched MP Consulting in a more consistent fashion, but I was clear from the beginning that I would take only a few assignments — I didn't want a large number of them. There are about six different kinds of work I do, but three are much more prominent. First, I am a certified executive coach through the Coaching Foundation of India, and I do a lot of coaching for senior leaders in the not-for-profit sector, because that is one of the gaps. It actually begins with explaining what coaching is, because while coaching has become acknowledged and well known in the corporate sector, it hasn't in the not-for-profit sector to the same extent. So there is explaining it, and then actually doing the work. That is one stream.

The second thing: if you are coaching senior leaders, you also need teams that back them up and work closely with them. So I build team leadership — facilitating team leadership workshops and so on. The third thing is what I call OD3: organisational diagnostics, design and development. From my own learning — 20 years running an organisation like YUVA in India, managing the merger of seven Oxfams into one Oxfam India, and other experiences — I have seen that there is a large alignment gap at various levels: alignment of strategy, of the people who work with the institution, and of structures and systems, all with the programmatic mission and programmatic strategy. How do we achieve that alignment across the organisation?

And of course, in a not-for-profit organisation, governance becomes very important. How do we strengthen boards? How do we move boards from compliance boards to performance boards to mission-driven boards? Those are the three stages of developing a board, and I help organisations through them. That includes what I call skill surveys of board members, which many institutions don't practise. I tell them that the skills available at the board level should be aligned with your strategy, because if the board is supposed to have effective oversight of your strategy, it needs those competencies and skill sets. Without them, the board will not be able to perform its governance and oversight role effectively and efficiently.

Then there is more programmatic work. I was involved with the Millennium Development Goals, and as you know, 2001 to 2015 was the era of the United Nations Millennium Development Goals, and 2016 to 2030 is the era of the Sustainable Development Goals, the SDGs. How do you link your very grassroots, micro-level interventions to these global frameworks? How do we locate your work within the global and national frameworks — what are the national development plans, and where does your intervention fit? How do we then leverage that intervention to influence policy? All of that is also part of organisational diagnostics and design: are you really capable of moving forward, and are you a forward-looking organisation, agile enough to face the newer challenges that come into the field?

Another area, which I haven't worked on much so far, is CSR strategy. Since I came back to India, the CSR regulations have been changing continuously, so for any CSR-related work, I engage specialists in that area to work with me. That's the nature of the work I take on. But the key thing for me is that whenever I take on an assignment, the first step is immersion — really understanding the organisation deeply. I don't open my mouth for at least one or two days, depending on the size of the organisation. I go to the field and talk to the community if it's an organisation working in communities; if it's an advocacy institution, I listen to their advocacy campaigns and strategies. Those one or two days are about understanding and immersing myself in the organisation, so that I start to understand both the pain points and the potential for change and growth — who the ambassadors of change are, who will become change agents in that organisation, and what the organisation needs at that point in time.

The last point I'll make about what I offer is about the type of leadership required for the phase an organisation is in, relating that to the external context, and then defining the nature of leadership needed. The leadership style I had when I established YUVA in 1984 is completely irrelevant in 2026. 2026 demands a totally different set of leadership approaches, leadership values, and understanding of an external world that is changing rapidly — the VUCA and BANI world we keep talking about. That impacts not only the corporate sector but the social sector in a big way, because the uncertainties are shared. You don't know what the next complex challenge will be or how you'll deal with it. So what I offer through my consulting practice is this experience of 40 years, but I also keep myself continuously up to date by acquiring new skills and newer understanding. I am now getting certified as a facilitator with the International Association of Facilitators, just as I did the coaching certification. And there is the use of AI in the work I do, whether coaching or organisational diagnostics and design — I've attended certificate programmes focusing specifically on that. While I'm building the skills and capacities of others, I also need to keep building my own. That's the approach. I hope I haven't taken too much time explaining what MP Consulting does.

Neharika Vohra: Not at all. I guess you can't run an organisation that focuses on learning without being a learner yourself. At MP Consulting, is it only you, or do you have a team?

Minar Pimple: The approach now to using human resources, or talent, is a network approach. For example, when I'm working with a partner that needs CSR work, I bring in a CSR consultant, and my role becomes a convening one — interpreting the organisation's needs to the CSR consultant, and managing that consultant to get the right inputs. I'll give you another concrete example. One organisation asked me to redesign compensation for their senior leaders, and at the whole-organisation level. I am not a compensation expert — that's a very specific HR role. So what is my role? My role is to ask whether the compensation package is aligned with the value system on which the organisation has been built, or whether it will create friction and gaps with the organisation's values — building more equality, people at the lower end of the scale getting relatively higher benefits and those at the upper end relatively lower ones, and so on. My role is to align it with the value system and create a philosophy of compensation, rather than design the compensation package itself.

The package was designed by compensation experts. But the basic philosophy was built on the surveys done for the not-for-profit sector — which positions are aligned with market surveys, which are completely misaligned, and how we can build a structure more aligned with the market while keeping the institution's value orientation intact. That's the kind of role I play, with expertise brought in. Another example: in 2019, when I started working with the Asia office of the large philanthropy, because it was a global philanthropy, I needed somebody with global HR expertise who understood different markets and different laws — because ultimately, the operations side of HR is basically about understanding local laws. So I brought that person in, while I was the principal consultant managing the whole organisational diagnostic and design process.

So I work through this kind of networked approach. There's another organisation that works specifically with MSMEs, called How Frameworks. They have identified seven different buckets of issues on which they want to help MSMEs, but a lot of the methodology and tools they've developed are also very useful for the not-for-profit sector. So I bring those consultants in to help design some of the initial diagnostic work, which needs to be looked at from a holistic perspective. So it's not about expanding staff strength within my organisation, but about using the networks of different expertise you have, and engaging them based on the particular needs of the organisation. It's more of a bespoke, customised consulting approach than a package, where everywhere you go you have the same deck and just keep repeating it with some modifications. That's not how I work.

Neharika Vohra: In finding these members of your network, I'm sure you also look for value alignment. How do you do that?

Minar Pimple: That happens in different ways. With the Coaching Foundation of India, for example, I'm part of the coaches' community. With How Frameworks, the founder is a very dear friend, so I've spent enough time to see that our values are fully aligned. I only bring people on board where there is very clear value alignment with my philosophy of creating leaders and not creating dependencies — giving institutions tools and equipping them to use those tools, so that the next time they have a problem, they don't have to come back to me; they have their own ways. As I keep saying, it's not giving somebody the fish, it's teaching them to catch the fish. How you do that is what I emphasise much more, and that is where the value alignment comes in. I don't engage anybody until I've had a proper conversation with them, and if possible an in-person meeting, because that makes a lot of difference — whether the chemistry works, whether their approach to the work is broadly similar to mine. Of course their specialities will differ, but is the broad framework of values they come from aligned with my values of supporting and empowering community leaders at various levels? All that gets done before I actually start engaging them.

Then there are different arrangements. If I have a package understanding with the organisation I'm serving, I manage all the payments to the vendors. In other instances, I tell the organisation, this is the person I want to work with on this particular issue, this is what he or she will help you with, and the cost is broadly this much — you negotiate directly with that party. So there are different models, and so far I haven't faced any difficulty, because I take a holistic approach, and organisations are pretty much convinced that if Minar is going to convene and manage this consultant, they're fine with the process.

Neharika Vohra: Excellent. Could you share how your own experience — starting and then handing over YUVA, and your subsequent roles with Oxfam, the UN Millennium Campaign, Amnesty International and the global philanthropy — has shaped your consulting today?

Minar Pimple: One great advantage I've had: with Oxfam, it was a merger of seven Oxfams into one Oxfam India, and I had the opportunity to work with Accenture Development Partnerships — ADP, the arm of Accenture that supports social sector organisations — who were consultants reporting to me as chair, because at that time we didn't yet have a fully functioning CEO, who would otherwise have anchored the consultants. That helped me tremendously. It was a two-year engagement, with two consultants based in Delhi working with the different Oxfams. I was based in Mumbai, but we had regular meetings, and I learned the methodologies and approach these organisations work with. Let's be very honest: any large-scale, complex

transformation or merger cannot be managed by one person. You need an institutional working group with you.

At Amnesty, I had Deloitte working with me very closely. My programme there was called "Moving Closer to the Ground." The idea was that you cannot do human rights work on, say, India from London, because the first comment will be, you people fly in from London, write the report and go away. So we wanted people from within the region — South Asia, for instance — to lead that work, to resolve the question of whether you really understand the idiom and culture of those countries, and how to deliver advocacy and human rights messages in a way that is more acceptable, without diluting them. Of about 600 people in the Amnesty International Secretariat, we moved 300 jobs from London to 15 different offices, which I was part of setting up. That needed someone with global exposure, and Deloitte was selected through the process.

My last assignment, with the large philanthropy, was a very interesting case. Other philanthropies were spending only 23% on themselves — salaries, offices, their own expenses — while this philanthropy was spending 28%. For a philanthropy of about \$1.4 billion, a saving of five percentage points is huge — millions of dollars that could then be made available to the social sector for its work. That was the challenge, and I worked very closely with two consulting firms. One was Bridgespan, which works specifically with the not-for-profit sector — as you know, they only work on the social sector and do no corporate work. The other was Deloitte. Bridgespan was much more focused on how to reorient strategy along with the restructuring we wanted to do, and Deloitte was much more engaged in creating new structures and new processes — so that even with a smaller number of staff, our effectiveness and efficiency would not go down. Rather, we would save costs and become more efficient — revamping the whole grant management system and all the different processes. I was the anchor for these external vendors.

Through all this, as you can understand, I got tremendous exposure to how large consulting firms operate — what the key things are in a merger process, what you do when you're shrinking an organisation, or distributing it across different centres, as in Amnesty's case. All those learnings were very useful in the global context. At the same time, whether you do it at a micro level or a mega level, the processes are fundamentally the same, because you want to ensure that the change process in the organisation is fully implemented. As you know, most organisational change processes fail at execution — almost 60 to 70% fail because there is no focus on execution. That is what I learned tremendously through these processes: managing large systems; ensuring that systems and processes are fully aligned with the competencies and capacities your people have — or, if they don't have them, recruiting people aligned to the competencies and skill sets the future organisation needs; and continuing the business while you are transforming. It's almost like building a plane while flying it, because you cannot stop the organisation's work while you are undergoing change. Those learnings have become critical and have helped me in everything I do, whether in the global consulting field or now, mostly, in India.

Neharika Vohra: Very nice, thank you. With so many years of experience in India and internationally, does effective leadership in the social sector require a particular mindset and disposition? Is it different from, say, the corporate sector or government?

Minar Pimple: Fundamentally, leadership is the same. What differ are the drivers of that leadership. The elements required to be a leader in the government or public sector, in the private sector, or in the social sector are broadly the same. You need a future-forward mindset, a positive mindset — one that challenges your people on the one hand, but also has the level of empathy that's needed. It's a combination of creating a learning, challenging environment while keeping an empathetic climate in the organisation or institution. All those facets are pretty much the same. When I give talks, I mention that ROI in the social sector means return on social impact, return on impact — not return on investment. So the metrics for how successful you are as a leader become different.

The other difference is that in the corporate sector you would generally have a much stronger leadership pipeline, because they can afford it — though that is changing now; if a CEO or the second line of leadership is suddenly taken off, there isn't always someone who can walk into those positions immediately. Earlier that wasn't the situation; you had a pipeline. In the not-for-profit sector, it's not that organisations don't want this — they simply can't afford it. So you will generally have a large gap between the CEO or ED of an organisation, the second line of leadership, and then the third line. It's not easy for that kind of leadership cascade to move seamlessly, and that's another challenge we face in leadership work with the not-for-profit sector. But the facets, Neharika, are the same. I don't see any big fundamental difference — though, of course, the particular requirements will differ with each institution's mission.

Some institutions' missions are about directly impacting communities and helping people on the ground, while others aim to bring about policy change. The facets an ED needs for policy change will be totally different from those needed in a community-based, community-driven, community-impact-obsessed organisation — or in a secondary organisation, a support organisation. That has been quite a big change I've seen since coming back to India: over the last 20 years, large organisations

like Dasra and ILSS have come up and become more impactful — organisations that mobilise resources and then distribute them. That's a different kind of role, and the leadership there will be completely different. The last point I will make is that, irrespective of where you are, what caste, class and gender you come from makes a lot of difference to leadership even today. People keep saying it doesn't, but your access changes. If you come from a more privileged background and you lead an NGO, you have totally different access to high-net-worth individuals willing to support you than, say, a local group led by a woman working on domestic violence in a small district headquarters. She will not have that access — she may herself have survived domestic violence and taken the radical step of organising women against it, but she won't have that access. So I'm giving you an example of how caste, class, gender and the community you come from make a difference to the kind of leadership requirements you have.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you — that's a very insightful point. You said there isn't much difference across kinds of organisations. But within social impact organisations, there are almost three or four different kinds: some do advocacy, some build communities, some work on capacity building — in education, health and so on — and some focus entirely on one specific problem. In your experience, are the leadership requirements very different across these?

Minar Pimple: There, they are different, as I was explaining. If you take an organisation dedicated only to, say, water, the expertise required for its leadership will be completely different, because its focus is water — of course it takes up related issues, but the focus is water. Or organisations that work only on child labour. Others work on, say, education — the classic example I give is Pratham, which has built a fantastic network for impacting mainstream systems on the quality of education, and ASER, one of their very well recognised products globally, has become hugely impactful. But you do need people who are specialised in that particular sector.

Then there are organisations like YUVA, which work through a more composite package of interventions, from direct community work to advocacy at the global level. For example, on climate change, they are working globally on urban heat, which has become a big challenge everywhere — the city you're sitting in, Ahmedabad, is among the highest in terms of the heat factor. How that sector thinks is different: you need somebody with a good understanding of community processes on the one hand, and on the other, an understanding of the global stage — what spaces are available for advocacy, and how to leverage your community experience into creating the policy changes you need at the global, national and city levels. It's really great to see organisations like YUVA now having memoranda of understanding with cities to contribute to building their climate action agendas. That happens because they're recognised as bringing ground experience, but also a more scientific understanding of what needs to be done on the issue. So that leadership will be totally different from the leadership of a single-sector organisation.

Neharika Vohra: Absolutely. In helping organisations develop their leaders, you said you first immerse yourself and listen. What are some of the other methods you use? Some examples would be very useful — without naming the organisations, of course.

Minar Pimple: I'll give you an example. With one organisation, I'm doing only coaching for their senior leaders. The brief I got was that the founder wants to exit, so he wants to build a second line and identify potential people who could replace him over the next two to three years. That's a very clear brief. I'm working with a team of about seven people across that organisation's ecosystem, and I'm approaching it with a dual intervention. One part is coaching, which is individual-focused work. The Coaching Foundation of India methodology involves about eight individual sessions, starting with an appreciative discovery dialogue to really understand the person, then doing 360-degree feedback, and using tools like the VIA survey of 24 character strengths, which shows where the person is strongest and which strengths they're using in a more limited way. We use different types of tools: the Johari Window, which builds self-awareness; the Choice Map, which shows whether your default mode is learner mode or judge mode, which in turn shapes how you operate with other people in the organisation. So there's a whole process we go through, and then we define the coaching agenda with the coachee's sponsor — the person who said, I find this person has potential but needs to be worked with — through joint conversations. That's one methodology, clearly adaptable, but broadly structured.

In this organisation, I also recognised that ultimately it's not just about individuals — it's also about collective leadership. So as part of the individual coaching, I offered two collective leadership workshops. One is finished, and I'll do the other at the end, since I'm now coming to the end of the process with the seven coachees. There we look at the collective thinking — what you've learned, and how it will be leveraged to take the organisation from this stage to the next.

With a second organisation, I said, let's start with a talent management survey, taking only your leadership team — a large team of 20 people. I did a talent management survey with all 20, which involved intense 45-minute to one-hour interviews with each of them on various aspects of themselves and the institution. I compiled a report, and that generated a collective

agenda, looking at common issues that came up, as well as individual agendas. As the next step, their supervisors got clear guidance: if you want to work with this person and develop his or her leadership capacities, this is the approach you should take. Then there were collective issues — three buckets were identified as critical for the organisation to move to the next stage, with task forces working on each. I facilitated a two-day leadership programme, which ended with a clear 90-day plan, and I'll do a review after three months. The second plan runs up to 31 March 2027, so that when the new financial year starts on 1 April 2027, they begin with a renewed understanding of the issues that have been worked on, and much greater clarity. That's a second kind of approach, again using various tools along the way.

As a facilitator, I might use Kabir's dohas — starting the morning session with a meditation, reading a Kabir doha and discussing what it means — or affirmation cards, which have a statement on one side and a question on the other: how does this relate to how you're feeling here and now? And there's a lot of work in pairs and triads — the kinds of things that happen in any facilitated process. I just cleared the report of that workshop yesterday, and I was myself amazed at how much we got done in two days. If it's structured properly, it's fascinating how strong the outputs can be. And to turn those outputs into outcomes, you need to hand-hold the organisation. So I told them I'll come back in the first week of September to review the first 90-day plan and how they've implemented it. They now have individual plans and commitments, as well as collective plans the organisation needs to follow through on.

In organisational diagnostics and design, I do something called a culture survey, because that is critical. I always say that all your issues lie in people, in systems and processes, or in structures — or a combination of these. And beneath all of this is organisational culture. I keep quoting that famous Drucker line, "culture eats strategy for breakfast," which is the reality in most of these organisations. In the NGO sector — and I'm sure it's the same in the corporate sector — people don't give adequate attention to what kind of culture is getting set. Then they suddenly realise the organisation is becoming very toxic: there are parts of the organisation that are very toxic, parts that are really vibrant, and they are living in that mixed reality. How do we change that? So we do the culture surveys and come up with a plan for what needs to be done. Again, the key thing I emphasise, Neharika, is that in each of these, I like to leave the tools behind, so that people in the institution can keep using them. They're not dependent on me. They can of course consult me and take my advice, but they are empowered to use those tools going forward.

Neharika Vohra: Wonderful. Do you sometimes find that leaders or people in the organisation say, please use this method because everybody is using it — appreciative inquiry, or anything else?

Minar Pimple: I do hear that, because they have heard of it or read about it superficially, and they will suggest it. My response is: you are asking me to become your consultant, and this is my process and methodology. I would not like to use a tool just because others use it popularly. My job is to see what is most relevant and impactful for you, based on my understanding, and I'll keep you informed at every stage. After my immersion, I'll give you my first tentative hypothesis of what needs to be done, and we'll talk about it. I'll explain broadly what I'm planning to do, and you can give your inputs. But the methodology is my autonomy, because you are bringing me in for my experience and my expertise — I bring both.

Maybe because I'm quite well known in the social sector, not many people question or challenge that. Just yesterday, I got a call from a funding organisation in India that wants me to facilitate their partners' meeting — they're bringing all their partners together. I said, I've been out of the country for 20 years. And they said their partners had heard that Minar has come back, and insisted that they get Minar to facilitate the gathering. So because of that, I think people sometimes don't insist on using this tool or that tool.

Neharika Vohra: That's good. So your own capability and legitimacy help.

Minar Pimple: That really helps tremendously. And one more thing, Neharika: I'm not in this for the sake of money, and that makes a lot of difference. If you're in it for the money, you may be willing to compromise. My India portfolio is 40% voluntary work, where I may even cover my own travel and stay — forget about charging anything — and 60% paid work, which cross-subsidises the unpaid work. When you come with that philosophy, it's a very different negotiation. The negotiations are about what needs to get done and why, more than how much you're going to pay me or what my charges will be.

Neharika Vohra: From some of the conversations we've had, it appears that two typical challenges for social impact organisations are funding and legitimacy. How do you see these playing out in the organisations you're involved with, and do you have any insight into how organisations should respond?

Minar Pimple: Funding has two or three facets. One facet is the legal framework, which is becoming more and more restrictive. As you know, there's a lot of difficulty in receiving money from abroad because of the tightening of the FCRA.

I'm speaking about India, but globally too there are countries with foreign agents acts — Russia, Hungary, Turkey — which are broadly similar in nature: they restrict outside money coming into the country, on the pretext that those resources destabilise the country. That's one externality linked to funding.

The second facet is how well you can create a narrative and story about your work — how present you are, how effective your website is, how well you can show your impact. There are organisations with a small impact that do a whole PR exercise around it because they have the capacity to do so, and there are organisations doing very meaningful work that don't have the capacity for social media, website management and so on. They get left behind. So the second thing is how much you are part of the public narrative — how well known you are for particular expertise, interventions and impact. That attracts or detracts funding.

The third thing, which I already mentioned, is the type of leadership. The caste, community and class you come from makes a lot of difference to your access, because it starts with language — how comfortable you are in English, for that matter, and how articulate you are. When I started YUVA in 1984, the length of a proposal was seen as a sign of the seriousness of whoever wrote it — 40 to 60 pages was the standard size for a project proposal seeking money. Now, if I give a 40-to-60-page proposal to any funder, I'll be rejected for its size alone. That's a huge difference. People now want a crisp two or three A4 pages that capture everything, with everything else in annexes if they want to look at it — and whether that first paragraph captures their imagination is what makes the difference. All those things have changed.

But the legal challenge I outlined first is a big one. There has also been large growth in Indian philanthropy, which is fantastic, and which I really appreciate. But some Indian philanthropies take their cue from it: if you don't have FCRA registration, they say, we don't want to fund you. That's a big challenge — as if FCRA has become the metric of legitimacy for whether an organisation gets funded. Some of us have been pushing hard on this, saying that an organisation not having FCRA should be a reason for you to fund it, rather than the reverse. And there's another challenge in the funding field. In a lot of philanthropy, even Indian philanthropy, you have young MBAs who have never set foot in the field and don't understand the complexities of managing any social or community process. They come with standard questions, without any experience, and on the basis of that conversation, they decide whether you're fit for funding or not. So some of us are pushing to say you have to immerse your programme officers in the ground realities. If they aren't immersed, they are not fit for the job of a programme officer — because that programme officer may hold a portfolio of, say, 100 crore rupees in a large philanthropy, and he or she is deciding who gets funded. But these are hard battles.

The second part, legitimacy, is linked with the first, but more broadly, what has happened now is that legitimacy is seen only as upward legitimacy. In the workshop I facilitated just last week, I said, I want to see your accountability mechanisms to the communities you work with. In YUVA, every five years we used to do a community evaluation of YUVA's programmes. We would make a full presentation of everything that had happened over the previous five years — what changed, what shifted — with key community leaders, women leaders, leaders from the bastis, and leaders from unorganised-sector unions all in the room together. We would have an independent panel; someone like A. R. Desai, then head of the sociology department at Mumbai University, chaired one such panel. So it wasn't just the community saying something with no independent people present — there were independent people listening. On that basis, a community feedback report would be prepared.

So the challenge is that legitimacy is seen only in the eyes of donors, the government, and your stakeholders upwards — it's upward accountability and legitimacy. Accountability towards communities, towards the stakeholders because of whom you actually exist, has weakened. That's one thing I'm trying to focus on: legitimacy is not only upward. The accountability and legitimacy you have within communities is as critical as the accountability and legitimacy you have with donors and government. That's the piece I'd like to emphasise.

Neharika Vohra: That's an excellent and very important point. Thank you for sharing it.

Minar Pimple: And that's another differentiator between the corporate sector and the not-for-profit sector. In the corporate sector, you are basically looking at shareholder value — are you creating it or not? Of course, there's the ESG framework and so on that people use. But in my understanding, in the social impact sector you need accountability mechanisms with the communities — with the people in whose name you work — absolutely established and institutionalised. Only then are you a truly legitimate organisation. Whether that is valued by funders now is another issue; let me not go there at all.

Neharika Vohra: That is a different matter. You've also been involved in restructuring European and African branches, as you mentioned. Are there some prominent challenges for global social sector organisations? It would be very useful to hear from you, given your experience both nationally and globally.

Minar Pimple: It's a different world. And you can't just say "Africa" — there's Southern Africa, Francophone West Africa, East Africa. Unfortunately, in each of those, who your colonisers were is what carries through in the organisational culture, the legal framework, the employment framework — all of that comes from those colonial structures, and that is the issue. In Latin America, again, French-speaking, English-speaking and Portuguese-speaking countries are very different. When you look at Brazil, it's a totally different ballgame from, say, Mexico. And that's just within continents. The cultures are different, the employment laws are different, and what helps you function is very different. In West Africa, for example, how good your connection is with the country's leadership makes a lot of difference. In Mexico, you don't necessarily need a great relationship with the president or vice president, but you do need good relationships with the secretaries of the relevant departments. I was dealing with all these people. In Lebanon, which is of course in the news all the time, what mattered was the relationship with the security apparatus. You might have a fantastic relationship with the president and the prime minister, but getting work permits and getting your staff located in the country was a totally different matter, because you needed security clearance, and the security establishment was at the top — not the foreign ministry.

So each country's specificities are very different, Neharika, and they need to be taken on board. That also affects the culture of how organisations work. A lot of the progressive work in the not-for-profit sector has come from the Americas — I'm not talking about the United States, but Latin America, which has a strong educational and social movement background. Much of the not-for-profit or social impact sector there came out of social movements — against military rule, for democracy — which were then carried forward, so a lot of the progressive thinking in the sector there comes from those histories. In India too, if you look at the post-Emergency era — Jayaprakash Narayan and his influence, and the adult education programme driven by Paulo Freire's ideas, which was a big thing after the Emergency — a lot came from that field, and many people came from the Gandhian and Sarvodaya movements. They came with a very clear orientation towards people's needs and people's issues — you can look at the whole history of the Bhoodan movement in Andhra, for instance. So those contexts make a lot of difference to the potential of each institution. Does that answer your question? Working in those countries requires different tactics and strategies.

Neharika Vohra: Yes. And in leadership, we always say that if you can't pay attention to context, you will never be successful. It's a very simple thing. Do you think India needs to invest more deliberately in building the capacity of the social sector itself? Do you see it as a pressing need, or are we doing fine?

Minar Pimple: That's a very interesting question, because we're facing a dichotomy. On the one hand, government is withdrawing from a lot of social sector work. Health, education, sanitation — even climate change and environmental management — are being privatised day in and day out. So there is actually more need for strengthening the social impact sector in the present context, not less. But on the other hand, the social impact sector is being squeezed. So new ways of thinking are needed — for instance, doing social impact work through for-profit organisations. That's a kind of thinking that is now coming up. Not as a standard formula, but I am suggesting to many organisations that they have one arm that is a for-profit company and another that is a not-for-profit foundation — preferably, if possible, a Section 8 company — and then a proper for-profit company. You then divide which services go under the for-profit and which activities go under the not-for-profit. This model is now coming up in quite a big way.

Geriatric care is one of the major issues emerging in India in a big way. I've seen many organisations I interact with — and of course my interest comes specifically from my own parents' need for geriatric care — where there is a for-profit that runs the geriatric care centres, while training caretakers and creating employment opportunities for them is not-for-profit foundation work, funded through CSR and others. So you see those kinds of combinations coming up in many sectors. It's a solution emerging from this dichotomy: needs in the social sector are increasing, but the sector is being squeezed. And in the private sector, people are running geriatric care centres because it's a big need with a big clientele, and people are willing to pay — admissions to geriatric care centres are not cheap. But what happens to those who cannot afford it? What happens to those older people? And that's a large number. Even middle-class families cannot afford to pay 50,000 or 60,000 rupees a month to take care of one parent — that's impossible. I'm giving that as an example. Is there any policy thinking around it? No. So there's this squeezing while the needs are increasing.

Neharika Vohra: That's interesting, because in one of our other podcasts, Industree talked about how they first set up a for-profit, and then a not-for-profit for training craftspeople. So it's something we've heard, and you're seeing it too.

Minar Pimple: Yes, I'm actually helping some people build what we call the architecture, or ecosystem, because individual organisations on their own are not sustainable. You need an ecosystem approach, bringing together different stakeholders to do the different things that need to be done.

Neharika Vohra: I think the ecosystem approach is something you've been practising since your YUVA days, since you were 23 — and Oxfam and Amnesty work that way too, and now MP Consulting. Could you share a little about the most formative experiences that shaped how you think about leadership, institutions, and what makes organisations endure?

Minar Pimple: The key thing I learned from the YUVA experience was when I was quite insistent on leaving YUVA. At that time my board chair was Gagan Sethi, of Janvikas in Ahmedabad. This was when YUVA was 15 years old. I said, Gagan, I wanted to leave at five years, I wanted to leave at ten years, and now it's fifteen — because I believe that if leaders outgrow the organisation, that's a good time for them to leave, and if the organisation outgrows the leader, that's also a good time for the leader to leave. Both are dangerous for the institution you have built. One of those two things happens in any institution — even in the corporate sector the experience is the same. At a particular time a leader is great, but once that time has passed, you need different competencies and capabilities from the earlier ones. As the famous saying goes, what got you here won't necessarily get you there. That's the basic principle we followed.

So Gagan insisted that we would never get another CEO who could handle YUVA's large canvas — organic agriculture in rural areas; work on genetically modified seeds and their impact on Indian agriculture; urban work on water, sanitation, housing rights and anti-eviction; working with hawkers, building hawkers' unions and their capacity to gain legitimacy, because they are part of the city's ecosystem; and leadership training on top of that. He insisted that we come up with an approach to set up different institutions. So over the next five years, Neharika — from when YUVA was 15 to when it was 20 and I finally left — I built YUVA Urban, a specialised institution working on urban issues; YUVA Rural, working on rural issues; and YUVA Consulting — because our idea was not to expand YUVA, but to expand the YUVA approach and methodology. We weren't building an empire, and consulting is one of the best ways to take your methodology across. Then there was the YUVA Centre, for assessing training needs and conducting training programmes for the social sector — and for government too; at that time we used to have people from government coming for training at the YUVA Centre.

The last institution I wanted to build, which I didn't build at that time but which YUVA has now come back to, is a YUVA Bank, on the lines of the SEWA Bank, so that you have holistic work across different areas. That was the ecosystem I wanted to build. Four institutions got built. YUVA Rural is active, based in Nagpur; YUVA Urban works out of Mumbai, and also in Assam; the YUVA Centre is very active and still hosts a lot of training programmes — we're now trying to see how to rejuvenate its training calendar. YUVA Consulting is a little dormant within the YUVA network now, because consulting is very much led by individuals. When I was there, we had large World Bank and ADB contracts; we did work in Visakhapatnam and many other places. But if you don't have individual CVs that can sell consulting work, it's difficult.

So from that experience I learned that you need institutions built around core competencies and capabilities, with clear missions, and people who will own those missions and build institutions around them. If I look today, almost 22 years after I left YUVA in 2004, the same approach is still valid: build core institutions around core missions, and then build institutional identity around those missions. That ecosystem approach still holds. Of course, you now have much better tools and much better legal structures. At that time we had the Section 25 company, which was a very different ballgame from today's Section 8 company for the not-for-profit sector. On the legal side, some things have become easier and some much more difficult. The FCRA side has gone completely in reverse, while company registration and those pieces have become much easier — there's much more ease of doing business.

Keeping all that in mind, I'm looking at how to apply the ecosystem approach. I'm doing the same with an organisation I'm working with in Marathwada. They have a long history of service work as a charitable institution. So we're looking at which of their activities are not charitable and can be run cost-effectively — they also do surveys, impact surveys and similar work. I told them those things don't need to sit in your charitable work; they can be in a clearly for-profit entity. Then your compliance burden in the not-for-profit is reduced quite considerably. Of course, you'll end up paying taxes, which is fine — that gives you another kind of legitimacy, because you're not only seeking money from others but also contributing. And you can have an arrangement between your for-profit institution and your social impact arm, where profits are pooled into the not-for-profit work. So you can do different things, and you also build a sustainable source of funding.

That learning has been very useful. Nobody even used the word "ecosystem" in 2004 — now it's become a common word that everybody uses. The model I had then was like the Tata Sons model. We had a combined board: all the chairs and all the EDs of all the institutions sat together on one combined board, which was considered the YUVA board. The values remained the same, the broad policies and human resource policies remained the same, and the rigour of compliance remained the same. We did all of that very deliberately.

Neharika Vohra: Very nice. My last question, Minar, has two parts. What would you tell your younger self today? And what would you tell young people today who might want to join this sector at some point?

Minar Pimple: When I look at my younger self, I think the ideal at that time was much more about strong leaders — someone driving the organisation, a taskmaster. Maybe that was what was needed at the time for YUVA to get established. But I've learned that in that process, the people you want to build don't actually get built, because they agree with what you want to do but not with how you want to do it. They're not aggressive, not very frontal. So my leadership has been tempered in recent years, through the UN and the external contexts of those organisations. I've tried to balance what I outlined earlier — challenge and empathy — and to encourage much stronger building of leaders in the organisation. That's why at the UN, every year at the annual review, people would say the Asia-Pacific team was the best, because it was delivering at the highest level on every metric we had. That came from learning how to manage the leadership process in a multicultural institution with lots of sensitivities.

So to my younger self, I would say: I could have been more empathetic with the people who worked very closely with me, and put more effort into building them as leaders. On the other hand, a lot of the people who worked with me are now leaders in their own right, leading organisations in India and outside, which is a fantastic source of pride. I'm not taking any credit for it, but they are so committed, and they say, we got our first exposure to what needs to be done and how it needs to be done — based on values, ethics and a particular framework of thinking — at YUVA; that's where we learned all this. When I get that feedback, I feel really good about it.

For young people, I think the key issue is, again, what your driver is — why you want to work in the social sector. Is the driver compassion, empathy, understanding social realities and trying to change them? How do you see your alignment with the Indian Constitution and its values — if we're talking about India — or, globally, how well do you understand the Universal Declaration of Human Rights? How are you inspired by those values and philosophies — humanistic philosophies? That's quite critical. There are no quick fixes in the social sector; you need to do the grunt work to come up with solutions. I still find that a lot of the young people I interact with are quite motivated and committed. They could have taken a corporate job, but they decide to come into the social sector at half the salary or less. But they are few and far between. After the Emergency, I remember my whole Master of Social Work class went into social activism, in various forms and fashions. I don't see that happening now — you have one or two people with that kind of different thinking. That's also fine; it's not a problem, because everybody has to chart their own life path.

But the critical things I find are lessening now are habits of reading, expanding your knowledge base and your thinking, and understanding which frameworks to use in a particular situation. And as I say, it's not only who you are today, but where you come from — having a strong awareness of your own roots, what they mean, and how they have shaped you is very important for a good leader in the social sector. Your journey becomes quite important. Then there's the attitude of learning — having the humility to learn from common people. They may not have gone to business school, but their wisdom is often absolutely stunning; they come up with solutions you haven't thought of. I always had a preference for working with women leaders, and at YUVA we were able to build many women leaders, because you learn so much from them. Their experience is truly grounded, both at the family level and the community level — how they're discriminated against, how they're always put down — and in spite of that, they want to do something meaningful and better, not only for their own families but for others. Those are the inspiring pieces. If young people have those inspirations and are looking for those spaces, they should jump in. I would really encourage it, because we do need a lot of young people coming in with new ideas, new thinking and fresh approaches — but with a clear humility to keep learning on an ongoing basis.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you. I really hope your parents are doing well — you've made a whole change in your life to be with them. And thank you for this deep conversation, which comes out of your deep understanding of the sector and of the work you've done. It's very rare to find people like you, so thank you so much for sharing all your wisdom and your work with us. All the best in what you do, and thank you again for your time.

Minar Pimple: Thank you, Neharika, for having me.